If there is one singular and unique feature of Chinese civilization that distinguishes it from other major civilizations it is the use of Chinese ideograms and characters, which survive with few changes to this day since they first appeared on oracle bones some 3,500 years ago, during the ancient Shang dynasty. The Chinese language has no alphabet. Each character is a word in itself, and a decent vocabulary requires the memorization of at least 3,000 characters. A scholar may aspire to a vocabulary of 5,000. There are several dialects of the Chinese language. Some like Cantonese spoken in the souther province of China, may be counted as a distinct language. However, while the language spoken in different parts of the country may differ widely, the written language is the same. When, as a diplomat, I would visit the city of Guangzhou I would often make myself understood by resorting to written Chinese. My Chinese interlocutors would do the same. It is only after the establishment of the People's Republic of China (PRC) that the Chinese spoken in the capital Beijing has been adopted as the standard spoken Chinese promoted across the country. 'Classical Chinese', in the words of one scholar, Peter Hessler, author of *Oracle Bones* , 'connected people over space and time . . . It provided a powerful element of unity to an empire that, from another perspective, was a mish-mash of ethnic groups and languages.' [1]

In China, there was a diversity of spoken languages but uniformity in the written script, and this was an important centralizing impulse. In India, spoken Sanskrit was the same as courtly and literary Sanskrit wherever it was used, but it could be written in different scripts. The emergence of vernacular languages with their own scripts created a diversity of literary forms and idioms not seen in China.

What is to be appreciated in this context is the importance of the written word in Chinese culture and the transformation of Chinese ideograms into an essential element in Chinese aesthetics. Calligraphy is a much-admired accomplishment, and characters appear as an integral component in paintings as well as Chinese pottery. (A brief note on the Chinese script has been provided at the end of the book in the Appendix.)

Contrast this with Indian culture, where the spoken word is pre-eminent.